

Strategy Gate Review

Ten questions somebody will eventually ask you. Better to ask them yourself, while the answer can still change.

1 • Has context shaped this? Fail: the document would work unchanged for a competitor.

2 • Is the diagnosis specific and credible? Fail: it opens with goals, or never says why the obvious answer has not already been taken.

3 • Is the tension visible, and correctly classified? Fail: harmony is implied. Or a paradox has been resolved by picking a pole, which reads as decisive and throws away something needed.

4 • Has direction been chosen? Fail: every option stays open. If nothing in the document costs anybody anything, nothing has been decided.

5 • Can somebody else use it as a governing rule? Fail: interpretation depends on the author, or it offers principles without a rule for using them.

6 • Has the boundary held? Fail: the strategic HOW has been replaced by tasks, budgets, workstreams or a timetable, or it says what to build without saying which choice it serves.

7 • Does it survive stress, and say how it changes? Fail: the answer changes because an attractive offer or pressure arrives. Or it claims it will never change, whatever the evidence.

8 • Are both clocks declared? Fail: no shelf life, so it ages quietly. Or no horizon, so it arrives after the negotiation. The horizon is set by what is moving, not by the diary.

9 • Is the organisation entitled to do this, and who says so? Fail: permission is assumed, nobody can name who grants it, or the internal and external accounts are two different accounts.

10 • Can it be stated plainly? Fail: clarity needs a preamble. Intent, problem, tension and its kind, direction, how, what is ruled out, and who said we may.

The record

WHICH GATE FAILED FIRST

WHAT THAT SAYS IS MISSING

WHAT WE ARE GOING BACK TO, AND WHO IS IN THE ROOM